CRICKET

A global sport of skill, strategy, teamwork and tradition

Cricket is a bat-and-ball sport played between two teams, usually of eleven players each. At its heart, the game combines individual skills—batting, bowling and fielding—with tactical decision-making.

From its early development in England to its enormous popularity across South Asia, Australia, the Caribbean, Africa and beyond, cricket has grown into one of the world's most widely followed sports.

Inside this guide

1. The game and its basic rules

2. Formats and major competitions

3. Skills, tactics and player roles

4. Cricket's global impact and modern evolution

1. How Cricket Is Played

A cricket match is played on a large oval field with a central rectangular pitch. At each end of the pitch stands a wicket made of three stumps and two bails. Two batters are on the field at a time, while the bowling and fielding team attempts to dismiss them and limit scoring.

Scoring

Batters score runs by running between the wickets or by hitting the ball to the boundary. A ball reaching the boundary after touching the ground scores four runs; a ball hit over the boundary without bouncing scores six.

Overs and innings

An over consists of six legal deliveries. An innings is a team's turn to bat. Depending on the format, teams may have a fixed number of overs or may bat until most batters are dismissed.

Common ways a batter can be dismissed

Dismissal	What it means
Bowled	The delivery hits the stumps and dislodges the bails.
Caught	A fielder catches the ball before it touches the ground.
LBW	The batter is out leg before wicket under specific conditions.
Run out	A fielder breaks the wicket while a batter is outside the crease.
Stumped	The wicketkeeper breaks the wicket while the batter is out of the crease and not attempting a run.

The basic objective is simple: score more runs than the opposition. The strategic depth comes from deciding when to attack, when to defend, where to place fielders, and which bowlers to use in different situations.

2. Formats, Roles and Strategy

Three major international formats

Format	Typical structure	Main character
Test	Up to five days; two innings per side	Long-form strategy, patience and endurance
ODI	50 overs per side	Balance between accumulation and attacking play
T20	20 overs per side	Fast scoring, aggressive tactics and high-impact skills

Player roles

Batters: Build the team's score. Some specialize in opening an innings, while others are selected for finishing or stabilizing the innings.

Bowlers: Deliver the ball with the aim of taking wickets and restricting runs. Fast bowlers use pace and movement; spinners rely on variation, flight and turn.

Wicketkeeper: Stands behind the stumps, catches deliveries and contributes to dismissals such as stumpings and catches.

All-rounders: Make meaningful contributions with both bat and ball, giving a team greater tactical flexibility.

Strategy

Cricket strategy changes with the format, pitch, weather, match situation and opposition. Captains choose bowling changes and field placements, while batters manage risk according to the required scoring rate. In limited-overs cricket, powerplay restrictions, death overs and strike rotation are especially important.

3. Cricket Around the World

Cricket developed in England and spread internationally through travel, trade and the British Empire. Today it is deeply embedded in the sporting cultures of countries across several continents.

Major international competitions

International cricket is organized across bilateral series and global tournaments. The Cricket World Cup is the premier men's ODI tournament, while the T20 World Cup is the major global short-format event. Test cricket also has a championship structure in the form of the World Test Championship.

Domestic and franchise cricket

Domestic competitions provide a pathway for players to develop and compete at a high level. Franchise leagues have also transformed modern cricket by bringing together international stars, local talent, short-format specialization and large audiences.

Technology and the modern game

Modern cricket increasingly uses technology to support officiating and analysis. Video review systems, ball-tracking, edge-detection technology and detailed performance data can help officials and teams make better-informed decisions.

Why cricket matters

Beyond statistics and competition, cricket creates shared sporting traditions. Matches can last for hours or days, allowing rivalries, tactical battles and individual performances to develop over time. The sport's combination of patience, precision, athleticism and teamwork is a major part of its enduring appeal.

Quick facts

Players per side	Usually 11
Legal deliveries in an over	6
Main skills	Batting, bowling, fielding
International formats	Test, ODI, T20

Cricket continues to evolve while retaining the traditions that make it distinctive.